

Sonnet 121

HSE74-A

By William Shakespeare

Tis better to be vile than **vile** esteemed
When not to be receives reproach of being,
And the just pleasure lost, which is so deemed
Not by our feeling but by others' seeing.

For why should others' false adulterate eyes
Give salutation to my **sportive blood**?
Or on my frailties why are frailer spies,
Which in their wills count bad that I think good?

No, I am that I am; and they that level
At my abuses reckon up their own:
I may be straight though they themselves be
bevel;
By their rank thoughts my deeds must not be
shown,

Unless this general evil they maintain:
All men are bad and in their badness reign.

William Shakespeare (1564 -1616)

- English playwright, poet and actor.
- He began a successful career in London as an actor
- 37 plays
- 154 sonnets
- 2 long narrative poem - Venus and Adonis, The Rape of Lucrece
- Called England's national poet, "Bard of Avon"
- Shakespeare was born and raised in Stratford-upon-Avon.
- Great Tragedies: Hamlet, Othello, King Lear, and Macbeth
- "not of an age, but for all time". - Ben Jonson

Sonnet

- A sonnet is a type of fourteen-line poet
- Derived from two words
- Italian Word 'Sonnetto' means little song or little sound
- Occitan word 'Sonet'
- Invented by Giacomo da Lentini for expressing courtly love
- Generally use a meter of iambic pentameter
- A pattern of stressed and unstressed syllables that creates the rhythm of lines of poetry.
- It follows a set rhyme scheme.
- use of end rhymes (rhymes at the end of each line),
- predetermined pattern - That pattern of sound is called a rhyme scheme.
- This is why sonnets are lyrical - one can sing with a regular sound pattern

Types of Sonnets

- Petrarchan
- Shakespearean

Italian Sonnet also called a Petrarchan sonnet

- Since the sonnet's invention in Italy in the 13th century
- Petrarch was a 14th century Italian Poet

- Petrarch is called as the Father of Humanism
- Petrarch is called as the Father of Sonnet
- Rhyming - abba abba cdc cdc
- 2 stanzas
- Eight line stanza called an octave
- six-line stanza called a sestet - cdc cdc / cdc dcd / cde cde

English Sonnet also called a Shakespearean sonnet

- The English poet Thomas Wyatt introduced the sonnet to the English language in the 16th century by translating the works of Petrarch from Italian.
- Sometimes referred to as the Elizabethan sonnet
- Rhyming - abab cdcd efef gg
- Three quatrains (stanzas of four lines)
- One Couplet
- It resolves all the problems introduced, developed and complicated above.
- It always carries a twisting end
- Concludes everything without any trace of question.

Composition and Publication

- First - the sonnets to the Dark Lady were composed (around 1591-95)
- Second - the procreation sonnets
- Third - The sonnets to the Fair Youth last (1597-1603)
- Published in 1609 by Thomas Thorpe
- Title of the book: Shakespeare's Sonnet never before imprinted (1609)

Address & Dedication

- 1- 126 addressed to a Young Man or a Fair Youth
- Fair Youth or Lord Sonnets
- Names: Fair Youth, Young Man, Lovely Boy, The Master Mistress of My Passion.
- 127 - 154 addressed to a dark lady - Dark Lady Sonnets
- Marry Fitten, Negro Prostitute,
- 1 - 17 sonnets talks about procreation - Procreation Sonnets
- 153 - 154 Sonnets are called Cupid Sonnets
- The sonnets were dedicated to a Lord W. H.,
- The identity of WH remains a mystery (William Herbert, the Earl of Pembroke)

Literary Devices

- **Caesura**: occurs when the poet inserts a pause into the middle of a line of verse
- "All men are bad and in their badness reign"
- **Alliteration**: the repetition of words with the same consonant sound.
- "vile" and "vile" in line one
- "receives reproach" in line two.
- **Enjambment**: occurs when the poet cuts off a line before its natural stopping point
- the transition between lines three and four as well as five and six.

Metaphor

- "sportive blood" (lustful desires).
- "frailer spies" (hypocritical critics watching the speaker's "frailties").

- “rank thoughts” (corrupt minds of the accusers).
- **Polyptoton:** Repetition of words from the same root.
- “my **frailties** why are **frailer** spies
- Emphasizes the accusers’ moral weakness compared to the speaker’s minor flaws.

Rhetorical Questions

- “For why should others’ false adulterate eyes / Give salutation to my sportive blood?”
- “Or on my frailties why are frailer spies?”
- These questions force readers to interrogate the validity of societal condemnation.
- **.Paradox:** A paradox is a statement that seems self-contradictory but reveals a deeper truth.
- “All men are bad and in their badness reign.”
- The couplet’s paradox invalidates moral authority: if all humans are inherently corrupt, no one can judge another.

Themes and Tones in Sonnet 121

- Hypocrisy and Honesty
- Judgment and Morality
- Identity and Perception
- Misanthropic Shade

McQs

- Who is considered as the father of Humanism
Petrarch
- Who is considered as the father of Sonnet
Petrarch
- Who invented sonnet
Giacomo da Lentini
- is a form of poetry which consist of 14 lines
Sonnet
- Sonnet is a form of poetry originated form which country
Italy
- The word sonnet is derived from the Italian word
Sonnetto - meaning - little sound or little song
- Which metric pattern is used by Petrarch in his sonnets?
Iambic Pentametre
- Petrarchan (Italian) Sonnet is divided its 14 lines into
An Octave and a Sestet
- Who introduced sonnet form in English?
Thomas Wyatt
- Shakespearean sonnet is divided its 14 lines into
Three Quatrains and a Concluding Couplet
- Rhyme scheme of Shakespearean sonnet is
Abab cdcd efef gg
- Rhyme scheme of Spenserian sonnet
Abab bcbf cdcd ee
- Rhyme scheme of Italian sonnet
Abba abba cde cde
- Metric pattern used by Shakespear in his sonnet?
Iambic Pentametre
- Each line in Shakespearean sonnet contains
Ten Syllables
- The common theme of Shakespearean sonnet is
Love
- 1- 126 sonnets are addressed to

Fair Youth

- 127 - 154 sonnets are addressed to
- Dark lady**
- Which sonnets are called Cupid Sonnets
153 and 154
- Which Sonnets are called Procreation Sonnet
1- 17
- Which poem begins like ‘ ’Tis better to be vile than vile esteemed’
Sonnet 121
- Sonnet 121 is addressed to
The fair Youth
- Which sonnet deals with the hypocrites and their nature of gossiping?
Sonnet 121
- The Phrase in sonnet 121 which has biblical affirmation
I am that I am
- Which Biblical text contains the quote “I am that I am”
Exodus
- William Shakespeare is known as
The Bard of Avon
- William Shakespeare was born in
Startford Upon Avon
- At the age 18, William Shakespeare married
Anne Hathaway
- There are number of works in William Shakespeare’s credit
37 Plays; 154 Sonnet; 2 Narrative poems
- In 1609 published William Shakespeare’s sonnets
Thomas Thorpe
- The sonnets are dedicate to
Mr. WH
- What is the theme of first Quatrain of sonnet 121
An evil reputation is worse than actual vileness
- Who began Sonnet sequence in English
Philip Sidney (Astrophel and Settall - 1591)
- A[art from 154 sonnets, William Shakespeare has written more sonnets in his plays
Six
- Which is one and only sonnet dwells on a religious theme
Sonnet 146
- What is the difference between Shakespearean sonnet and Spenserian sonnet
Rhyme Scheme
- Who called William Shakespeare an upstart crow?
Robert Greene
- Who said about William Shakespeare that ‘Sonnets were a key with which he unlocked his heart’?
William Wordswoth
- What is the theme of sonnet 121
Hypocrites and their nature of gossiping
- Or on my frailties why are frailer spies - figure of speech
Alliteration
- The concluding couplet of 121 reveals attitude of poet
Pessimistic